

Automate Your Work with OpenOffice.org Macros



Here's how to automate office work with the help of macros in OpenOffice.org, with a focus on spreadsheets management.

John and Sam work in the same office. They handle a lot of documents every day and use OpenOffice.org for the purpose. Of late, John manages to finish his work early, whereas Sam has to stay in late to finish his. Moreover, John's work is more accurate and organised than Sam's. So Sam is eager to know the secret of John's success. Can you guess?

Well, John has recently learnt how to program his OpenOffice.org suite. He has prepared macros for frequent tasks, and whenever there is a need for a lot of GUI operations, he makes it simple by automating them with macros. So just with a click or short-cut key, John has managed to avoid a lot of manual and mundane repetitive tasks.

Imagine a situation where you have to create a new spreadsheet daily, and copy certain data and processes from the previous day's sheet. This will take a substantial amount of time every day. However, by preparing a macro, just a click or key combination will complete your work in a fraction of the time taken earlier.



Note: OpenOffice.org, here onwards called OOo, comes with many

components like Writer for text documents, Calc for spreadsheets, Impress for presentations, Draw for diagrams, Math for formulae and Base for database purposes. OOo documents are based on the Open Document Format (ODF) from version 2.0 onwards. The present version of OOo is 3.0.1.

Overview of macros

A macro is like a script that can avoid a series of manual operations involved in GUI applications. In OOo, macros can be coded in many languages. In this article we consider one simple language—OOBasic (OpenOffice.org Basic) to develop our macros. It is a dialect of traditional BASIC.

Some flavours of OOo come with the support of VBA macros to make documents prepared in Microsoft Office interoperable with OOo. Go-oo, a version [<http://go-oo.org>] of OOo, is one such example.

OOo comes with built-in tools for the development of macros in OOBASIC, i.e., no external SDK or development tools are required. OOo provides a macro organiser to create and maintain, and an IDE to code, run and debug macros.